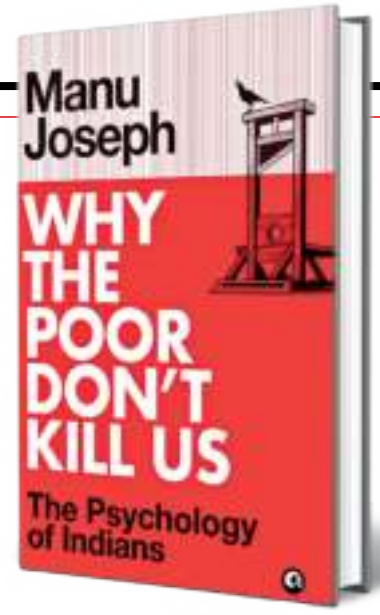
BOOKS ▸

No Fools Here

Manu Joseph's Why the Poor Don't Kill Us *deploys gripping prose to take an unsentimental—but not unsympathetic—look at India's impoverished classes*



WHY THE POOR DON'T KILL US
By Manu Joseph
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹599; 280 pages

This is a book—the title is self-explanatory—about 'us' and 'them'; the Indian middle class and the working class, the rich and the poor, and the gulf in between. Manu Joseph is not trying to sell Indian poverty to the West; he is making sense of it in fat-free, ideology-free, statistics-free and curiously empathetic but unsentimental prose. It makes for gripping reading, rich in anecdote and personal insight, informed by observations from the author's time as a reporter.

Every Indian has a theory about India, in a way that natives of European countries don't. Joseph himself is a compulsive theoriser (and interrogator), but a provocative one. He's not a 'perhaps' writer, bringing to the table sardonic certainty, told in a voice-of-god style. It's up to the reader how much of a believer she wants to become. You agree even as you disagree.

"The poor, taken together," Joseph writes, "are still meek. Considering their lives and the lives of the rich that they see every day, they appear to be far less furious than they should be." The polemical essays cover considerable ground, from the photograph of Kalahandi's Dana Majhi carrying his dead wife on his shoulder, to the author's own hard-up youth, selling Funskool toys door-to-door; from the symbolism of air-conditioning to the five-star buffet.

In a chapter called 'What Moneylenders Know', Joseph writes on the Syrian Christian moneylenders of Kerala and the "Jain pawnbrokers of Madras". On the Olympics: "The middle class opts out of this sporting torment and instead becomes a consumer of national pride... like they employ drivers, they employ the poor to overcome the realities of India and somehow triumph against other nations." On class: "Every layer of Indian society subsidizes the life of the layer above by working for exploitatively low wages." And: "The poor in a rich country are like a bitter Reddit page trapped inside Instagram." One suspects Naipaul would have given this book a glowing endorsement. ■

JOSEPH HAS MANY THEORIES **ABOUT INDIAN POVERTY, DRAWING FROM HIS REPORTAGE** AS WELL AS YOUTH SELLING TOYS DOOR-TO-DOOR

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra

BOOKS ▾

OUTSIDE THE LINES

Penguin's *Longform* series is a **welcome effort to showcase India's comics creators,** especially upcoming, marginalised and subversive voices

A slogan painter battles his demons of becoming irrelevant in the 21st century before he finishes writing on the wall: "The world speaks many tongues." Some chapters later, a priest starts questioning his job when his loved ones die. He regains his faith after reading the *Bhagavad Gita*. Meanwhile, an avuncular cat teaches a kitten how to inspire kindness so the world can become a better place. Despair and soldiering on are the themes of *Longform 2025*, a thoughtful anthology of 17 graphic narratives. There is also a fantastic interview with journalist-cartoonist Joe Sacco (*Palestine*, *Footnotes in Gaza*).

This is the third edition of the series, where the Longform Comics Collective brings to-

LONGFORM: AN ANTHOLOGY OF GRAPHIC NARRATIVES
Edited by Pinaki De, Debkumar Mitra, Argha Manna PENGUIN VINTAGE **₹1,499; 320 pages**

